While the lion's share of this investment will come from the government, the private sector is increasingly focusing on the energy and transportation sectors, it says. "Enhanced connectivity through modern roadways, railways, ports and airports will reduce transportation costs and improve trade efficiency," says Nilachal Mishra, partner and head of government & public services, KPMG India. Such a huge outlay helps. "Investments in reliable utilities and digital infrastructure will boost industrial productivity and foster innovation. According to studies by the Reserve Bank of India and the National Institute of Public Finance and Policy, every rupee spent on infrastructure yields a 2.5 to 3.5 rupee gain in GDP," he explains.

THRUST ON SMART MOBILITY

In one of the first major decisions in its third term, the Modi government has allocated an additional Rs 50,000 crore to build eight new high-speed national highway corridors totalling 934 km. These include a swanky, access-controlled, four-lane Ayodhya Ring Road, a six-lane corridor between Agra and Gwalior and a four-lane Kanpur Ring Road, among others. The centrepiece of this initiative is an 80-km, eight-lane elevated corridor between Nashik Phata and Khed near Pune, designed to drastically ease logistics movement. Over the next two decades, the number of greenfield access-controlled high-speed expressways, like the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway, is expected to grow significantly, with over 50,000 km planned. Officials estimate a total capital expenditure of more than Rs 20 lakh crore for these projects.

The rail network expansion plan for the next decade includes multi-tracking the busiest routes and converting the Golden Quadrilateral routes connecting all major metro cities into semi-high-speed corridors. Today, the Railways operates over 50 pairs of its latest offering, the Vande Bharat Express trains, India's version of world-class train travel. The country has not only electrified nearly its entire rail network but has also expanded it by approximately 25,000 km through new lines and multi-tracking—almost double the achievement of the previous decade. Additionally, the Metro network is now operational in 20 cities across the country. "We see world-class mass mobility as a key catalyst in taking India's dynamic economy forward," says Olivier Loison, head of multinational rolling-stock major Alstom India. Loison thinks India's investment in future-ready mobility solutions also boosts local economies and communities by bridging the gap between people and opportunities, businesses and talent. "It's clear that robust infrastructure development is the cornerstone of resilient, inclusive and sustainable cities."

In the mobility space, aviation is experiencing an unprecedented boom post-Covid. More Indians are flying now than ever before, and the number is set to grow further as more airports and airlines are in expansion mode. This surge has propelled India to become the third-largest domestic aviation market in the world, with 15.5 million seats, surpassing Brazil, which now ranks fourth. The US and China remain the top two. Indian airlines such as Air India, IndiGo and others have placed orders for over 1,000 new aircraft, the largest order value for any country. IndiGo, which aims to double its fleet size by 2030, anticipates that India's aviation sector will contribute even more to the GDP in the coming years. The future of India's aviation infrastructure will include multiple aviation hubs, says Girish Nair, partner and aviation sector lead, KPMG India. "India has a tremendous potential to create multiple hubs by strengthening our aviation ecosystem to funnel the huge domestic and foreign traffic, thereby emerging as a global aviation hub," he explains.

BUILDING RESILIENCE

Along with scaling up its infrastructure, India has also actively joined the global conversation on keeping future assets resilient to climate disasters. "Disasters are increasing in frequency and severity," says Amit Prothi, director general, Centre for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI), an India-headquartered inter-governmental body. The CDRI estimates India's potential loss of infrastructure due to disasters related to natural hazards and climate change at $31.6 billion (Rs 2.6 lakh crore) a year, with floods alone accounting for $28 billion (Rs 2.3 lakh crore). "By embedding resilience into infrastructure development... [India] will avoid infrastructure being destroyed or damaged, reduce service disruption, ensure more reliable public services, social development and accelerate economic growth."

In the elite club of developed nations and major economies, undertaking large-scale projects to construct and expand public assets is par for the course. China began this process long ago and is now reaping the benefits. Over the past 20 years, it has focused on massive infrastructure spending to establish it-

TAKEAWAYS

- Major infrastructure spending in power, roads and railways under the National Infrastructure Pipeline
- New highways and expressways like the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway to cut travel time and boost competitiveness
- Vande Bharat trains, network electrification, and metro expansion across 20 cities
- India is the third-largest domestic aviation market with over 1,000 new aircraft ordered